

◀ Peaches of immortality

On this vase, a group of immortals offer peaches grown by the Queen Mother of the West on the sacred Mt. Kunlun. Reportedly, the peaches ripened only once every 6,000 years and Emperor Wu of Han was one of the few mortals to have tasted them.

In pursuit of eternal life

From around 300 BCE *fangshi* (recipe masters) developed a reputation as seers and purveyors of elixirs that would guarantee immortality. They were of particular interest to the emperors, who could afford to fund the *fangshi*'s experiments, but the results were not always beneficial.

Qin Shi Huang, the first emperor, became obsessed with the search for eternal life. He sent demands to regional governors to despatch rare herbs back to the capital and neglected the business of government later in his reign. In the end, his patronage of the *fangshi* was deadly—he ingested a pill one of them prescribed that contained poisonous mercury, collapsed, and died.

Immortality and alchemy

Many Chinese alchemists sought to transform one substance into another by altering the balance of the Five Elements (considered in China to be Earth, Wood, Metal, Fire, and Water). The idea of achieving perfection, and so harmony with the cosmos, was of particular appeal to Daoist masters, who developed distinct schools of alchemy.

Weidan (external alchemy) was one school. It resembled the European quest to change base metals into gold, although the Daoists viewed this transformation as a metaphor for immortality. Like the potions of the *fangshi*, their elixirs were keenly sought by emperors seeking eternal life. Another school, *Neidan* (internal alchemy), aimed for spiritual refinement and immortality, through meditation, breathing exercises, and a good diet to improve the body's store of *qi* (vital energy).

Followers of both Daoism and Confucianism, and to an extent Buddhism, sought order, or at least a grasp of how the world was structured. They developed a notion of complementary opposites, *yin* (the dark or passive aspect of things) and *yang* (the light and active component), which needed to be in perfect harmony. When combined with the Five Elements and the movements of the planets (themselves interconnected—for instance, Wood for Jupiter and Fire for Mars), the forces of *yin* and *yang* produced a complex system of balance. Astrologers interpreted this system to foretell the future, while magicians sought to control and manipulate it.



▲ Daoist alchemist

A Daoist master watches as a miraculous elixir of immortality separates out on the tripod in this woodcut from a Qing Dynasty alchemical text published in 1605.

IN PRACTICE

Stone of immortality

Jade was prized in China from Neolithic times onward for its durability and its lustrous green sheen. Jade objects first appeared around 3000 BCE and, by the Shang and Zhou Dynasties, had become formalized into a series of ritual shapes, including *bi* (flat disks) and *cong* (tubular containers). Over time, jade became strongly associated with imperial power. It was sharpened into blades or crafted into ceremonial suits made up of pieces of jade joined with wire or silk. The suits encased members of the royal family in death when they were buried, as the stone was believed to slow the decay of flesh. Jade had purely magical uses, too: sorcerers used it to create amulets to ward off bad luck, and Daoist alchemists ground it up to mix with their elixirs.

This jade pendant was made in the 3rd century BCE, during the Zhou Dynasty.

